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Paid Family Leave and the Role of Industry Gender Composition on Maternal Labor Supply

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1 Responses to Comments from A8

- Define male-dominated industries in introduction: "In male-dominated industries . . . In female-dominated industries . . . Mixed industries" → "In male-dominated (< 40% female) . . . In female-dominated (> 60% female) industries . . . Mixed industries (40%-60% female)"
- We don't know that this ("the career cost of actually taking leave is steep enough that women may avoid using PFL even when formally entitled to it") is true in introduction: "the career cost of actually taking leave is steep enough that women may avoid using PFL even when formally entitled to it" → "norms surrounding leave-taking **may** discourage some women from using PFL even when formally entitled to it" (soften the language so I don't overstate anything)
- Strange wording in data section ("I restrict the sample to mothers who have **worked over 0 hours** the past year"): "worked over 0 hours" → "reported positive weeks worked" (hours is actually wrong because I meant weeks!)
- Inconsistent use of individual/woman/mother in Proposed Empirical Test section: made it all consistent using mother i instead of individual i since I referred to mothers throughout the section.
- Predetermined industry composition in Assumptions section was initially framed as a potential threat to identification: revised to state that industry composition is predetermined and not affected by PFL.
- Event study in Figure 2 does not clearly support the significant DDD estimate in Table 2: added a clarifying sentence to the Event Studies Results section explaining that the absence of a clear dynamic pattern does not contradict Table 2 because the static coefficient pools all post-adoption variation into a single estimate, while the event study splits that same variation into ten year-by-year coefficients. This makes it difficult to detect a consistent post-adoption pattern with only 8 treated states.

2 Abstract

While the literature documents positive average effects of paid family leave on maternal labor market outcomes, little is known about whether these effects vary across industries with different workplace norms and gender cultures. Using data from the Current Population Survey (1999–2025), which includes

states with more recent PFL adoption such as Connecticut and Massachusetts, I estimate a difference-in-differences-in-differences model that interacts state-level PFL adoption with industry gender composition to identify heterogeneous effects on post-birth weeks worked among mothers with infants. Results show that PFL increases paid weeks worked by approximately 2 weeks among women in mixed industries (40–60% female) relative to women in male-dominated industries. These findings suggest that the gender makeup of an industry shapes how much paid family leave affects mothers' work decisions, with implications for how policymakers design and promote leave programs across sectors.

3 Introduction

The United States remains the only high-income country without a national paid family leave policy. Since California enacted the first state-level paid family leave (PFL) program in 2004, twelve additional states and Washington D.C. have followed, with programs varying in generosity and eligibility requirements. Despite this gradual expansion, it remains unclear not just whether PFL works on average, but for whom and under what conditions it is most effective. Answering this question matters for policy design because if PFL's benefits are concentrated in industries where workplace norms already support leave-taking, then the workers who most need formal policy protection (e.g., those in male-dominated industries where accommodations are scarce) may require more support. Understanding this heterogeneity is essential for designing equitable policies that reach the women they are intended to help.

[Goldin \(2014\)](#) argues that the gender earnings gap persists because high-paying jobs reward total availability disproportionately (e.g., a corporate lawyer working 80-hour weeks may earn three or four times a colleague working 40, not twice, because clients pay a premium for constant personal access). Workers who step back face large penalties, and since women historically bear more caregiving responsibilities, they may experience these penalties most. This suggests PFL effectiveness likely varies across industries. In male-dominated (< 40% female) industries like finance or law, norms surrounding leave-taking may discourage some women from using PFL even when formally entitled to it, predicting the smallest labor supply response. In female-dominated (> 60% female) industries like education or healthcare, flexible norms already support leave-taking, so PFL converts informal accommodations into formal paid leave and I predict a small difference in paid weeks. Mixed industries (40%-60% female), where informal norms neither deter leave-taking nor already substitute for formal policy, may see the largest gains in paid weeks as formal PFL fills a genuine gap. Testing this pattern provides direct empirical evidence on whether industry-level workplace norms shape the returns to formal family leave policy.

This paper asks: do paid family leave policies have heterogeneous effects on weeks worked among mothers with infants, depending on whether their industry is male-dominated, mixed, or female-dominated? Using data from the Current Population Survey from 1999 to 2025, I classify industries by their 1999 female employment share into three groups and estimate a baseline difference-in-differences (DD) model followed by a triple difference-in-differences (DDD) model that interacts PFL adoption with industry gender composition. I complement the regression analysis with event study estimates that characterize dynamic effects and test the parallel trends assumption.

The results reveal significant heterogeneity. Women in male-dominated industries show a small negative, insignificant effect ($\beta = -0.600$, $se = 0.571$), though we cannot draw strong conclusions given the lack of statistical precision. Women in mixed industries work approximately 2.0 more paid weeks relative to male-dominated industries following PFL adoption ($\beta = 2.037$, $se = 0.580$, $p < 0.01$). Women in female-dominated industries show no significant differential effect relative to male-dominated industries ($\beta = 0.160$, $se = 0.547$), though we cannot rule out positive, negative, or null effects for this group.

This paper makes two contributions. First, no prior study has examined whether PFL effects differ systematically across industries with different gender compositions, and this paper fills that gap. Second, this paper contributes to the literature by extending the sample period through 2025, incorporating state PFL programs effective by 2022 including policies in Massachusetts, Washington D.C., and Connecticut. Prior studies have focused primarily on California, New Jersey, and Rhode Island, which adopted PFL relatively early. By including later adopters, this paper provides evidence on whether the effects of PFL generalize beyond the early-adopting states that have dominated the existing literature.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 reviews the related literature, Section 3 describes the data, Section 4 presents the empirical strategy, Section 5 reports results, and Section 6 concludes.

4 Related Works

Ever since the first PFL state policy went effective in California in 2004, there have been many papers that have studied its positive impact on labor market outcomes and labor force participation for women (Baum et Ruhm, 2016); (Chang, 2021); (Das et Polachek, 2015); (Kang et al., 2021); (Rossin-Slater et al., 2013); (Stock et Inglis, 2021). As a result, when more states adopted the PFL policies years later, the work extended to multiple states, typically including California, Rhode Island, and New Jersey since they

all adopted the policy relatively early (Bartel et al., 2018); (Byker, 2016). In these early papers, studies found that PFL increases the likelihood women return to work after giving birth (Baum et Ruhm, 2016); (Chang, 2021); (Kang et al., 2021); (Rossin-Slater et al., 2013), increases the takeup rate for maternity leave (Baum et Ruhm, 2016); (Das et Polachek, 2015); (Rossin-Slater et al., 2013), and provides greater levels of benefit for certain groups, such as women of color and lower wage workers (Chang, 2021); (Kang et al., 2021); (Stock et Inglis, 2021).

These studies largely treat PFL effects as uniform across industries, which leaves open the question of whether workplace norms moderate policy effectiveness. Building on Goldin's (Goldin, 2014) framework linking industry structure to flexibility penalties, recent work demonstrates that occupational segregation shapes both the availability of family-friendly workplace norms and workers' willingness to use leave (Blau et Kahn, 2017); (Elser et al., 2022); (Goldin et Katz, 2016). For example, among 806 women in private-sector jobs, blue-collar workers were 10.9% less likely to take 12 weeks of paid parental leave compared to white-collar workers, and took an average of 1.5 fewer fully-paid equivalent weeks (Elser et al., 2022). No existing study examines whether industry norms shape how much PFL actually changes women's work behavior. This is exactly one of the gaps this paper addresses.

5 Data

The analysis uses data from the yearly Current Population Survey (CPS), which is conducted by the U.S Census Bureau. Households are interviewed for four consecutive months, leave the sample for eight months, and then return for four more months. The data contains individual and household microdata that includes demographics, work and education information, and results from surveys (e.g. computer use, food security). I also use Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED), which provides economic data from scores of national, international, public, and private sources. More specifically, I use FRED to control for time-varying state-level confounders such as minimum wage policies.

The main analysis uses yearly data for the period 1999-2025 with the sample restricted to women of childbearing age (18-44) who were employed in the last year and have a youngest child who is an infant. Starting the sample period in 1999 ensures that the data starts approximately 5 years before the first state-level paid family leave (PFL) program was effective, which was in California during January 2004. Ending the sample period in 2025 ensures that there is at least 3 years of data since the most recent PFL program was effective (out of the states in this paper), which was in Connecticut during January 2022.

For my analysis, I create dummy variables for whether each observation occurs before or after the policy in a given state. Since most state policies go effective during the month of January and CPS data provides observations every March, I include the implementation year as a part of the post-policy period. This is because even if a woman gives birth before the effective policy date, as long as she gave birth in the last 12 months, she meets that eligibility requirement. I also create dummy variables for which state a mother lives in during the time of data collection. CPS data allows for this because it records the respondent's state of residence at the time of the survey. In addition, I create dummy variables for the gender composition of each woman's industry using CPS data during the 1999 base year. Industries where women constitute more than 60% of workers are classified as female-dominated, those between 40-60% are classified mixed, and those where women constitute less than 40% are classified as male-dominated (Table A1). This specific calculation was done using all women and all men working in those industries according to 1999 CPS data, not the restricted sample that is used for the main analysis. Industry gender composition classifications are approximately stable across the sample period (Figure A1). Because switching industries during pregnancy and the immediate postpartum period is uncommon, a mother's industry gender composition is treated as predetermined and not itself an outcome of policy exposure.

The main analysis evaluates labor supply outcomes among women who have worked in the last year and have a youngest child who is an infant. I restrict the sample to mothers of childbearing age (18-44) with infants because these women recently experienced childbirth, making them the population most likely to be affected by PFL policies. I also restrict the sample to mothers who have reported positive weeks worked in the past year since they are most likely to meet PFL eligibility requirements, which typically require a minimum earnings or hours threshold in the prior year (Table A2). Since the sample without restricting age had outliers of age 15 and 85, I chose to restrict the sample to women of age 18-44 to reduce the noise from self-reported responses (Bailey, 2025).

In my analysis, it is important to note that I use broader industry-state and industry-year fixed effects due to the sample size of 31,012. Because the sample of currently employed mothers of childbearing age with infants is concentrated across a subset of industries, using the full set of approximately 200 detailed industry codes produces sparse cells with single observations that cannot contribute to identification. Thus, I went through all the industry categories to reasonably split them into six broad industry categories (Table A3).

In addition to fixed effects, I also control for time-varying state-level confounders that may be correlated with both PFL adoption timing and maternal labor supply, I merge an additional state-year variable from

FRED into the CPS data. The variable is the effective state minimum wage, which is defined as the maximum of the state and federal minimum wage in a given year. For states with state minimum wage below the federal minimum wage (Alabama, Louisiana, Mississippi, South Carolina, and Tennessee), the federal minimum wage rate is used instead because that is what employers are required to pay employees. Both variables are merged into the CPS data at the state-year level so that one minimum wage value is added to every observation in a given state and year. It is also included as controls in all regression specifications to account for concurrent labor market policies that may affect labor supply in this case.

The variable descriptions used in my analysis are provided in Table 1. The outcome variable, paid weeks worked in the past year, captures total labor supply during the year surrounding childbirth and therefore reflects changes in labor attachment after birth (Figure 1). The distribution is heavily right-skewed, with approximately 58% of the sample reporting 52 weeks worked. This reflects that the majority of employed mothers with infants maintained full-year employment, though this figure includes weeks of paid leave, vacation, and sickness. The remaining observations are spread thinly across lower values, suggesting a smaller subset of mothers who reduced labor supply substantially around childbirth. The calculations for these tables were conducted on the dataset that restricted the sample to women who were ages 18-44, had a youngest child under the age of 1 (infant), and reported positive weeks in the past 12 months. Each observation represents an individual mother surveyed in a given CPS year. The data are repeated cross-sections rather than a panel, meaning individuals are not tracked over time.

6 Empirical Methods

6.1 Proposed Empirical Test

First, I perform a baseline DD model to estimate the average effect of PFL policies on labor supply for women in my restricted sample. Equation (1) below shows the DD equation estimated in this study:

$$Y_{ist} = \beta_1 PFL_{st} + \alpha_s + \lambda_t + X_{it}\gamma + Z_{st}\phi + \varepsilon_{ist} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{ist} denotes weeks worked in the past year for mother i in state s at time t , PFL_{st} indicates whether a PFL policy is in effect in state s at time t . α_s and λ_t are state and year fixed effects, and X_{it} is a vector of individual and household controls including age, marital status, number of children, education, and race/ethnicity. Z_{st} is a vector of time-varying state-level controls including the state minimum wage, and

ϕ is the corresponding vector of coefficients. The coefficient β_1 captures the average effect of PFL on weeks worked among all mothers with infants who have worked in the past year. Standard errors are clustered at the state level because the treatment variable varies at the state level. Mothers in the same state share the same treatment status and are subject to the same state-level conditions, so their outcomes are correlated in ways that standard errors need to account for.

For my main empirical test, I examine whether the effect of PFL differs across male-dominated and female-dominated industries because these industries may have different workplace norms and levels of job flexibility. Equation (2) below shows the main DDD equation estimated in this study:

$$Y_{ist} = \beta_1 PFL_{st} + \beta_2 Mixed_i + \beta_3 Female_i + \beta_4 (PFL_{st} \times Mixed_i) + \beta_5 (PFL_{st} \times Female_i) + \alpha_s + \lambda_t + \alpha_{js} + \alpha_{jt} + X_{it}\gamma + Z_{st}\phi + \varepsilon_{ist} \quad (2)$$

where $Mixed_i$ is an indicator equal to 1 if the mother's industry is mixed (40–60% female) and $Female_i$ is an indicator equal to 1 if the mother's industry is female-dominated (>60% female). α_{js} denotes industry-state fixed effects, constructed by interacting each mother's broad industry category with their state of residence to absorb time-invariant differences in labor supply across industry-state cells. α_{jt} denotes broad industry-year fixed effects, constructed by interacting each mother's broad industry category with year to absorb national industry-specific shocks common to all states. Industry fixed effects are based on 6 broad industry sectors rather than detailed industry codes to avoid sparse cell problems given the sample size. Z_{st} and ϕ are as defined in Equation (1). The coefficients β_4 and β_5 capture the differential effect of PFL for workers in mixed and female-dominated industries relative to male-dominated industries. The robustness of these estimates to alternative fixed effects specifications is shown in Table A4.

6.2 Assumptions for Empirical Test

- **Parallel Trends:** In the absence of PFL, outcomes in treated and untreated states would have followed similar trends. This can be tested by performing the event study specification shown in Equation (3) for women in each industry group:

$$Y_{ist} = \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k^g Event_{kst} + \alpha_s + \lambda_t + X_{it}\gamma + Z_{st}\phi + \varepsilon_{ist} \quad (3)$$

where $k = 0$ denotes the first year we can observe the policy's effect and β_k^g denotes the average

difference in weeks worked between treated and control states at each point in event time k , for industry group g . If β_k^g for $k < -1$ are close to zero and insignificant, this supports parallel trends within each industry group.

- **No Differential Industry Trends:** The DDD design additionally requires that industry groups do not follow differential pre-existing trends relative to each other. While Equation (3) tests parallel trends within each group, a separate event study directly tests whether the gap between industry groups was already changing before PFL adoption. This can be tested using the event study specification shown in Equation (4):

$$Y_{ist} = \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k Event_{kst} + \sum_{k \neq -1} \gamma_k (Event_{kst} \times Mixed_i) + \sum_{k \neq -1} \delta_k (Event_{kst} \times Female_i) + \beta_2 Mixed_i + \beta_3 Female_i + \alpha_s + \lambda_t + \alpha_{js} + \alpha_{jt} + X_{it}\gamma + Z_{st}\phi + \varepsilon_{ist} \quad (4)$$

where β_k is the dynamic effect of PFL for mothers in male-dominated industries at event time k , γ_k is the additional effect for mothers in mixed industries relative to male-dominated at event time k , δ_k is the additional effect for mothers in female-dominated industries relative to male-dominated at event time k . If γ_k and δ_k for $k < -1$ are close to zero and insignificant, this supports the assumption that industry groups did not follow differential pre-existing trends prior to PFL adoption.

- **No Concurrent Policy Changes:** No other policies affecting maternal labor supply change simultaneously with PFL in ways that differentially affect industry groups. I partially address this by controlling for minimum wage as a covariate. Adding the control addresses that concern by partialing out the effect of other labor market policies on weeks worked. The minimum wage coefficients are statistically insignificant across all specifications in the main DDD, but their inclusion does not drastically change the main estimates (Table A4). This suggests that the differential effect of PFL across industry groups is not driven by concurrent changes in these state-level conditions.
- **Predetermined Industry Composition:** Industry gender composition is defined using 1999 CPS data and is therefore predetermined with respect to PFL adoption. This ensures that industry group classification is not affected by the policy, so estimates reflect heterogeneity across pre-existing industry categories.

6.3 Problems Anticipated

- **Staggered Adoption Across States:** Treatment effects may be heterogeneous because of reasons such as differing eligibility requirements, maximum benefit duration, wage replacement rates, and levels of job protection for each treated state's policy (Table A2). Thus, the generosity of PFL varies substantially across treated states and over time as programs have been expanded. Under staggered adoption with heterogeneous treatment effects, [Callaway et Sant'Anna \(2021\)](#) and [Sun et Abraham \(2021\)](#) show that the standard difference-in-differences estimator may be biased because states that are already treated can serve as implicit controls for later-adopting states. A natural check would be to implement the [Callaway et Sant'Anna \(2021\)](#) estimator; however, with only 8 treated states across a 26-year panel, the state-year cells required by the estimator are too sparse to produce reliable estimates. Thus, I address this concern through event study estimates, which allow treatment effects to vary over time and provide a pre-trends test, and through robustness checks across alternative fixed effects specifications (Table A4) to show that results are stable regardless of the choice of fixed effects.
- **Heterogeneous Control Group:** The control group includes states that have never been treated and states that have not been treated yet. States anticipating future PFL adoption may adjust behavior in advance. This would drive the estimated effect of PFL toward zero, which would underestimate the true policy impact. These concerns are partially addressed by the event studies, which allow treatment effects to vary over time and provide a visual test for pre-existing trends.
- **Takeup Rate and Eligibility Data Unavailable:** Since CPS data does not provide takeup rates or eligibility data for PFL, it is difficult to know which people in the sample are eligible and actually take part in the PFL program. Since the sample includes women who may not meet their state's specific eligibility threshold (e.g., minimum hours or earnings requirements), the estimates capture the intent-to-treat effect of living in a treated state rather than the average treatment effect among eligible and participating mothers.
- **Heterogeneity in 2020:** Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, there may have been different industry-specific shocks in treated versus non-treated states. For example, healthcare in California may have had a different 2020 experience than healthcare in Texas, and California happens to be a treated state while Texas is not. That differential effect is not absorbed by any of my fixed effects. I would need industry-state-year fixed effects to absorb it, but that is perfectly collinear with my treatment variable since PFL varies at the state-year level.

7 Estimation

This study mainly estimates the DDD specification to evaluate the differential effects of PFL on women in differing industries. Additionally, I conduct several robustness checks to provide evidence for the validity of assumptions of the DD and DDD models I used in the main analysis.

7.1 Main Results

The baseline DD estimate in Column (1) of Table 2 shows no statistically significant average effect of PFL on weeks worked among mothers of childbearing age with infants. The coefficient on PFL is 0.042 weeks ($se = 0.429$), and the 95% confidence interval of $[-0.80, 0.88]$ means we cannot rule out effects ranging from a reduction of nearly one week to an increase of nearly one week. The positive point estimate is consistent with the intuition that paid leave laws mechanically convert unpaid time off into paid weeks worked, but the data are too imprecise to draw conclusions about the direction of the average effect. This motivates the DDD approach, which allows the effect of PFL to vary across industry gender composition groups.

The DDD estimates in Column (2) reveal meaningful heterogeneity. For women in male-dominated industries (the reference category), the coefficient on PFL is -0.600 ($se = 0.571$), with a 95% confidence interval of $[-1.72, 0.52]$. We cannot rule out positive, negative, or null effects for this group. The null result is consistent with workplace culture in male-dominated industries discouraging leave-taking even when formal entitlement exists. [Hideg et al. \(2024\)](#), in an Australian context, find that women in male-dominated occupations face career penalties for taking longer parental leaves, suggesting that women may avoid claiming PFL benefits altogether if they anticipate such penalties. However, because the coefficient is statistically insignificant, this interpretation remains speculative.

The coefficient on $PFL \times Mixed$ is 2.037 ($se = 0.580$, $p < 0.01$), with a 95% confidence interval of $[0.90, 3.17]$. This indicates that women in mixed industries work between 0.9 and 3.2 additional paid weeks relative to women in male-dominated industries following PFL adoption, and we can rule out zero at conventional significance levels. The positive point estimate represents roughly 4.6% of the sample mean, which is economically meaningful. One plausible explanation is that mixed industries occupy a middle ground so they are accommodating enough that leave-taking carries lower career costs than in male-dominated industries, but formal PFL still fills a genuine gap that does not exist in already-flexible female-dominated industries. The presence of more female coworkers may also reduce the social and

informational barriers to claiming benefits. To support this potential explanation, [Dottori et al. \(2024\)](#), in an Italian context, find that a higher share of female peers who took parental leave significantly increases a mother's own likelihood of taking leave. However, we can only speculate on mechanism as the data identify the differential effect but cannot directly test why it arises.

The coefficient on $\text{PFL} \times \text{Female-dominated}$ is 0.160 ($\text{se} = 0.547$), with a 95% confidence interval of $[-0.91, 1.23]$. As with male-dominated industries, we cannot rule out positive, negative, or null effects. Two explanations are plausible but indistinguishable with available data: women in female-dominated industries may already have informal leave accommodations that leave little room for formal policy to add, or lower average wages in these industries may mean fewer workers meet states' earnings eligibility thresholds for PFL.

The contrast between the significant positive effect for mixed industries and the null effect for female-dominated industries demonstrates that PFL effectiveness does not follow a simple linear pattern across the female share distribution. This motivates a more granular examination of heterogeneity across the female share distribution.

7.2 DDD Heterogeneity

To explore this pattern more carefully, I replace the three-group industry classification with seven groups defined by approximately 10 percentage point intervals of female share, allowing the effect of PFL to vary across a more granular set of categories. The distribution of observations across female share bands is reported in Table A7. This specification serves as both a robustness check on the main DDD results and a richer characterization of where in the female share distribution the effects are concentrated.

Table A6 presents the continuous female share specification with seven industry bands. The results do not reveal a clear monotonic pattern across the female share distribution. While two coefficients are statistically significant ($\text{PFL} \times 30\text{--}40\%$ female ($-2.124, p < 0.01$) and $\text{PFL} \times 60\text{--}70\%$ female ($-2.792, p < 0.01$)) the remaining five bands are statistically insignificant and alternate in sign, with no systematic relationship between female share and PFL effectiveness (Figure A2). Notably, the significant negative effects at 30–40% and 60–70% female do not fit a simple monotonic pattern. If female share were increasing or decreasing PFL effectiveness in a consistent direction, we would expect coefficients to increase or decrease smoothly across bands. Instead, many adjacent bands are insignificant and of alternating signs.

Overall, the specification does not reveal a systematic relationship between industry female share and PFL effectiveness beyond what is captured by the three-group classification in the main DDD results.

7.3 DDD Robustness

Table A4 presents robustness checks on the main DDD estimates across alternative fixed effects specifications and with the addition of a state minimum wage control. Column (1) shows the baseline specification with only state and year fixed effects, Column (2) adds broad industry-state and industry-year fixed effects, Column (3) adds the effective state minimum wage control without industry fixed effects, and Column (4) includes all of the above. The key finding from Table 2 is very stable across all four specifications. The coefficient on $\text{PFL} \times \text{Mixed}$ ranges from 2.045 to 2.250 across columns and remains statistically significant at the 1% level in every specification. This shows that the differential effect of PFL for women in mixed industries is not driven by industry-specific trends, time-invariant industry-state differences, or concurrent minimum wage changes. The coefficient on $\text{PFL} \times \text{Female-dominated}$ remains small and statistically insignificant across all four columns, ranging from 0.129 to 0.165. The PFL baseline effect is negative and insignificant throughout, ranging from -0.600 to -0.836. The stability of the main estimates across specifications that progressively add controls and fixed effects suggests that the differential effect of PFL for mixed industries is unlikely to be driven by industry-specific trends, time-invariant industry-state differences, or concurrent minimum wage changes.

7.4 Event Studies

Figures 2 and A3 and Tables A8 and A9 present the event study estimates. The pre-treatment coefficients ($k < -1$) are small and statistically insignificant across all three industry groups in both the DD and DDD specifications. This provides support for the parallel trends assumption. One exception is the coefficient on $k = -5$ for male-dominated industries in the DD specification (-2.470, $p < 0.05$), though this likely reflects noise rather than a systematic violation of parallel trends. In the post-adoption period, the DDD event study in Figure 2 and Table A9 does not reveal a clear or consistent dynamic pattern. The differential effect for mixed industries is positive and significant at $k = 2$ (5.551, $p < 0.01$) and $k = 5$ (2.424, $p < 0.01$), but is small and insignificant in surrounding periods, which means the effect is not smoothly increasing over time. Similarly, the differential effect for female-dominated industries shows no consistent pattern after PFL adoption, with coefficients alternating in sign and being insignificant. The absence of a clear dynamic pattern does not necessarily contradict the significant DDD estimate in

Table 2. The static coefficient averages the effect across all post-adoption years and states into a single estimate, while the event study splits that same variation into ten separate year-by-year coefficients, each estimated from far less data. With only 8 treated states adopting PFL at different times, the individual year coefficients are too noisy to trace a clean path even if the average effect is real.

8 Conclusions

This paper examines whether paid family leave policies have heterogeneous effects on maternal labor supply depending on the gender composition of a woman's industry. Using Current Population Survey data from 1999 to 2025 and a triple difference-in-differences design, I find no statistically significant average effect of PFL on weeks worked among mothers with infants. However, the DDD estimates reveal meaningful heterogeneity: women in mixed industries (40–60% female) work approximately 2 more weeks in the year following childbirth relative to women in male-dominated industries after PFL adoption, a 4.6% increase relative to the sample mean. Women in female-dominated and male-dominated industries show no significant differential response. These results are robust across alternative fixed effects specifications and the inclusion of state-level minimum wage controls, and pre-treatment event study coefficients are small and insignificant across industry groups, supporting the parallel trends assumption.

Overall, the findings are consistent with the interpretation that PFL's effectiveness may depend on the industry environment in which women use it. In male-dominated industries, one possible explanation for the null result is that formal entitlement may be insufficient to overcome the career costs of actually taking leave, though we cannot rule out positive or negative effects. In female-dominated industries, one possible explanation is that flexible workplace cultures were already supporting leave-taking before PFL arrived, leaving little room for the policy to add more. Again, the data cannot distinguish this from other explanations. The significant positive effect for mixed industries is the most robust finding. One possible explanation for this is that PFL may be most effective in industries that are partially accommodating but where informal norms alone are insufficient. Taken together, these patterns suggest the same policy may have very different effects depending on where a woman works, though directly testing the mechanisms behind this heterogeneity remains an important direction for future work.

Several limitations are worth noting. First, even though the sample contains 31,012 observations, it is spread across 26 years, 51 states, and three industry groups, which leaves relatively few observations in each cell and makes it harder to detect statistically precise effects. Second, the CPS does not record whether

a woman was actually eligible for PFL or whether she used it. This means the estimates reflect the effect of simply living in a state with PFL, not the effect of actually receiving benefits, which likely understates the true impact on women who actively took leave. Third, only 8 states adopted PFL during the sample period, which is too few to implement more sophisticated methods designed for settings where states adopt policies at different times (e.g., staggered adoption framework of [Callaway et Sant'Anna \(2021\)](#)). This means the standard DD estimator may be imprecise if the policy had different sized effects in different states. Similarly, while the DDD event study supports parallel pre-trends across industry groups, the post-adoption differential coefficients for mixed industries are imprecisely estimated and do not trace a smooth path, which likely reflects the small number of treated states and heterogeneous treatment timing across adoption cohorts rather than an absence of effect. Finally, the analysis assumes that PFL did not cause women to switch into different industries. If women moved into more accommodating industries after PFL was introduced, the estimated effects would partly reflect that sorting rather than the true effect of PFL within each industry type. This assumption is plausible since new mothers are unlikely to change jobs right before or right after giving birth, though we cannot rule out that some women switched industries before becoming pregnant in anticipation of PFL.

These limitations suggest several directions for future research. As more states adopt PFL, future work could use the [Callaway et Sant'Anna \(2021\)](#) estimator that better accounts for states adopting the policy at different times, which would produce more reliable estimates. Additionally, analyzing a single state using government administrative records (e.g., tax or unemployment data linked to birth records) would reveal which women were actually eligible for and used PFL, allowing for a more precise estimate of the policy's true impact. Richer data would also allow researchers to look at more detailed industry categories rather than the six broad groups used in this paper.

These findings also have direct implications for policy. If PFL has the largest effect in mixed industries but little effect in male-dominated ones, then simply passing a PFL law may not be enough to help women in industries where taking leave carries the highest career costs. To make PFL work for these women, policymakers may also need to strengthen job protection laws, reduce stigma around leave-taking in male-dominated workplaces, or run targeted outreach campaigns so that women in these industries feel safe actually using the benefits they are entitled to.

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Tables and Figures

Table 1: Summary Statistics by Industry Gender Composition

	Full Sample	Male-Dominated	Mixed	Female-Dominated
<i>Labor market outcome</i>				
Weeks worked (last 12 months)	43.882 (12.732)	44.765 (12.303)	42.667 (13.835)	44.293 (12.164)
<i>Demographics</i>				
Age	29.991 (5.536)	30.401 (5.421)	29.526 (5.976)	30.126 (5.296)
Number of children	1.943 (1.048)	1.958 (1.078)	1.928 (1.074)	1.947 (1.024)
Married	0.740 (0.439)	0.750 (0.433)	0.674 (0.469)	0.773 (0.419)
<i>Education</i>				
Less than high school	0.062 (0.241)	0.077 (0.267)	0.097 (0.296)	0.038 (0.192)
High school diploma	0.218 (0.413)	0.237 (0.425)	0.268 (0.443)	0.185 (0.389)
Some college	0.287 (0.452)	0.276 (0.447)	0.271 (0.445)	0.298 (0.458)
Bachelor's degree or above	0.433 (0.495)	0.409 (0.492)	0.363 (0.481)	0.478 (0.500)
<i>Race/ethnicity</i>				
White, non-Hispanic	0.679 (0.467)	0.655 (0.475)	0.643 (0.479)	0.705 (0.456)
Black, non-Hispanic	0.096 (0.295)	0.086 (0.280)	0.096 (0.295)	0.100 (0.299)
Hispanic	0.149 (0.356)	0.172 (0.377)	0.174 (0.379)	0.129 (0.335)
Other race/ethnicity	0.076 (0.265)	0.087 (0.283)	0.087 (0.281)	0.067 (0.249)
<i>State-year controls</i>				
Effective state minimum wage (\$)	7.253 (2.146)	7.245 (2.249)	7.213 (2.155)	7.277 (2.111)
Observations	31,012	4,905	9,249	16,858

Notes: Sample: mothers with infants (youngest child age 0) with any employment in the past year, 1999–2025. Means reported with standard deviations in parentheses. Male-dominated: <40% female in 1999. Mixed: 40–60% female. Female-dominated: >60% female in 1999. Minimum wage measured at the state-year level. Effective minimum wage defined as the maximum of the state and federal minimum wage.

Table 1 (continued): Variable Ranges for the Full Restricted Sample

	Min	Max
<i>Labor market outcome</i>		
Weeks worked (last 12 months)	1	52
<i>Demographics</i>		
Age	18	44
Number of children	1	9
Married	0	1
<i>Education</i>		
Less than high school	0	1
High school diploma	0	1
Some college	0	1
Bachelor's degree or above	0	1
<i>Race/ethnicity</i>		
White, non-Hispanic	0	1
Black, non-Hispanic	0	1
Hispanic	0	1
Other race/ethnicity	0	1
<i>State-year controls</i>		
Effective state minimum wage (\$)	5.150	17.500

Notes: Sample: mothers with infants (youngest child age 0) with any employment in the past year, 1999–2025.

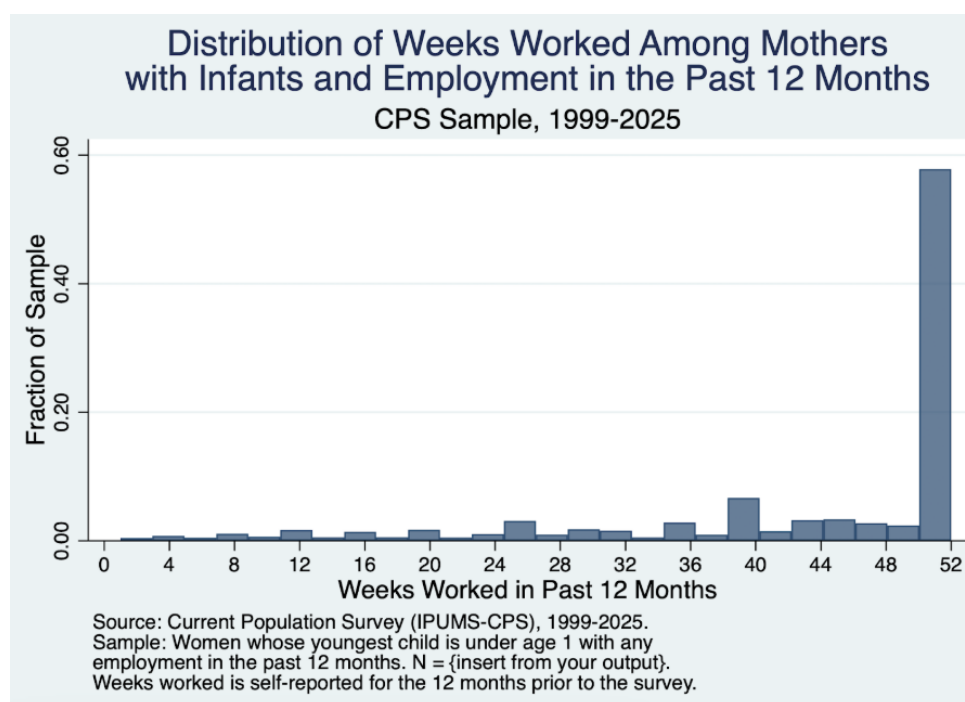
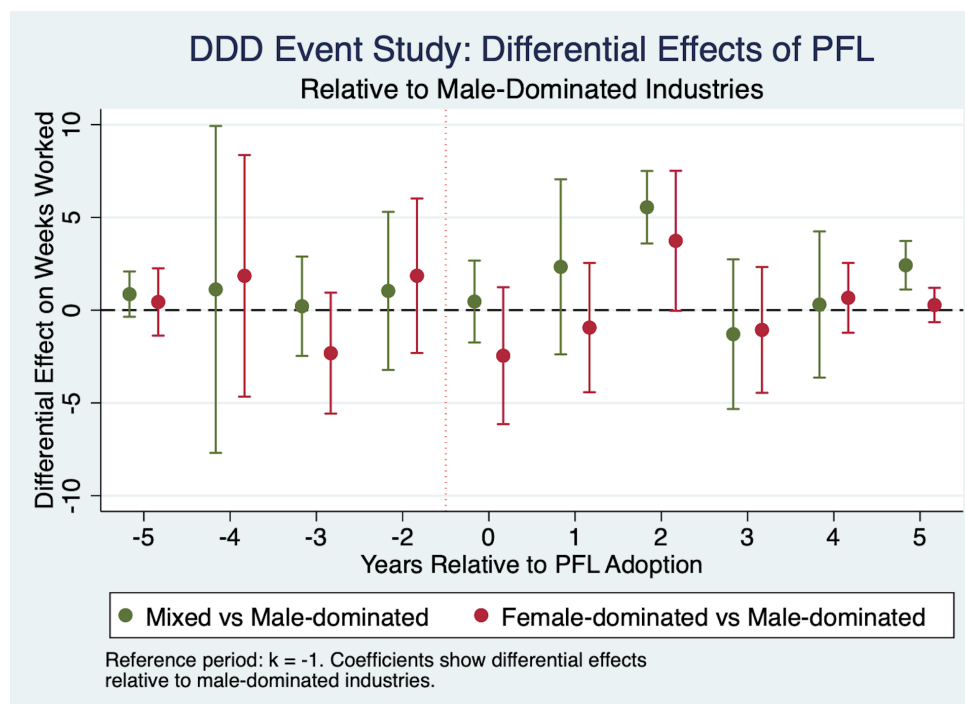
Figure 1: Histogram of Weeks Worked Distribution for the Restricted Sample

Table 2: Effect of PFL on Weeks Worked

	(1)	(2)
	DD	DDD
PFL	0.042 (0.429)	-0.600 (0.571)
PFL × Mixed		2.037*** (0.580)
PFL × Female-dominated		0.160 (0.547)
State FE	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes
Broad Ind-State FE	No	Yes
Broad Ind-Year FE	No	Yes
Min Wage Control	Yes	Yes
Observations	31,012	31,012
R ²	0.067	0.087

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. Reference category: male-dominated industries (<40% female in 1999). Industry-state and industry-year fixed effects based on 6 broad industry sectors. Individual controls included in all specifications: age, marital status, number of children, education, and race/ethnicity. State-year control: effective state minimum wage.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Figure 2: DDD Event Study Estimates of PFL Effect on Weeks Worked by Industry Gender Composition

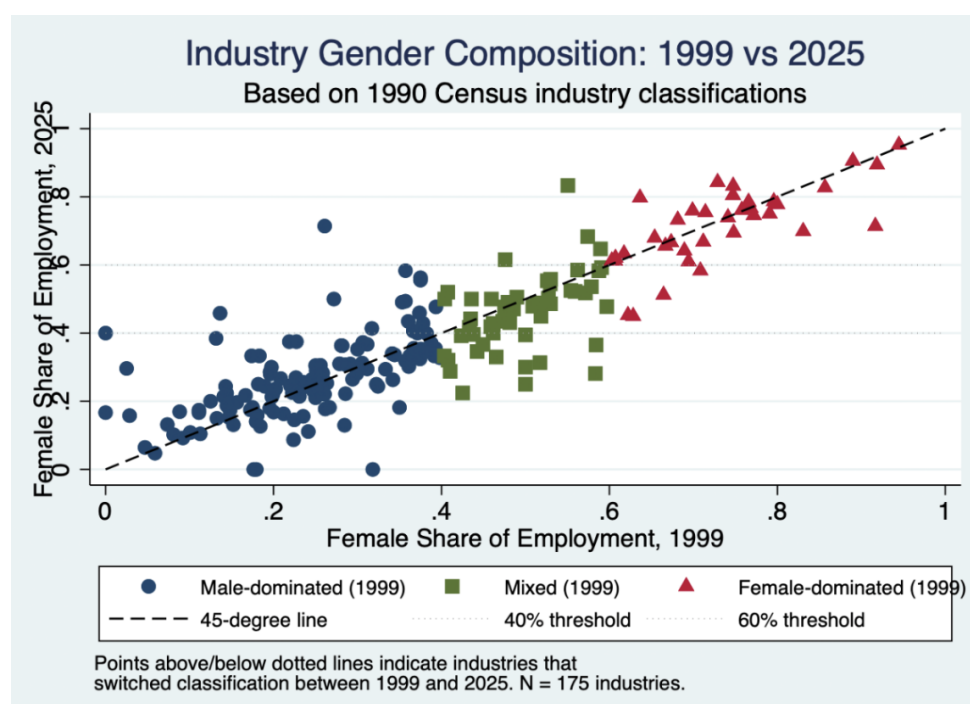
A Appendix

Table A1: Distribution of Observations by Industry Group (1999 Classification)

	Number of Observations	Percent (%)
Male-dominated (<40% female)	4,905	15.82
Mixed (40–60% female)	9,249	29.82
Female-dominated (>60% female)	16,858	54.36
Total	31,012	100.00

Source: Current Population Survey (IPUMS-CPS), 1999–2025. *Sample:* Women (age 18–44) whose youngest child is under age 1 with any employment in the past 12 months. Industry groups defined by 1999 female share of employment.

Figure A1: Scatter Plot of 1999 vs. 2025 Female Share



Source: Current Population Survey (IPUMS-CPS), 1999 and 2025. Each point represents a broad industry category. The dashed line indicates the 45-degree line of no change.

Table A2: Employee Eligibility for Paid Family Leave across U.S. States

State	Year	Effective	Employee Eligibility
California	2004		Paid at least \$300 in wages during the base period.
New Jersey	2009		Must have met one of the following requirements: 20+ weeks of covered New Jersey employment earning \$283+ per week, or earned \$14,200+ during the base period.
Rhode Island	2014		Paid RI wages and TDI/TCI fund contributions, and earned at least \$16,800 in the base period. Alternatively, employees qualify if they earned \$2,800 in one base period quarter, their total base period taxable wages were at least 150% of that highest quarter, and their total base period taxable wages were \$5,600 or more.
New York	2018		Current employee of a covered employer for 26 or more consecutive weeks (or 175 days for part-time). For an employee's own disability, the employee must have worked for a covered employer for four or more consecutive weeks (or 25 days for part-time).
Washington	2020		Worked for at least 820 hours in four out of the five quarters before leave application.
Massachusetts	2021		Earned a minimum of \$6,300 in the last four quarters and 30 times the potential weekly unemployment benefit.
Washington D.C.	2020		Must either spend over 50% of work time in the District of Columbia (DC) for a covered employer, or be DC-based, regularly spend substantial work time in DC, and spend 50% or less of work time for that employer outside DC. Additionally, they must have been a covered employee for some or all of the 52 weeks preceding the covered event.
Connecticut	2022		Earned a minimum of \$2,325 in the highest earning base-period quarter and been employed by an employer in the preceding 12 weeks.

Source: <https://nationalpartnership.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/02/state-paid-family-leave-laws.pdf>

Table A3: Broad Industry Categories for Fixed Effects

Industry	Number of Observations	Percent of Total Sample
Agriculture, manufacturing, and utilities	3,870	12.48
Trade (wholesale and retail)	6,112	19.71
Finance, insurance, and business services	5,714	18.43
Personal/social services and public admin	4,176	13.47
Health services	6,285	20.27
Education	4,855	15.66
Total	31,012	100.00

Notes: Source: Current Population Survey (IPUMS-CPS), 1999–2025. Sample: Women whose youngest child is under age 1 with any employment in the past 12 months.

Table A4: Robustness to Broad Industry Fixed Effects

	(1) Baseline	(2) + Ind FE	(3) + Min Wage	(4) Full
<i>Policy variables</i>				
PFL	−0.836 (0.642)	−0.753 (0.538)	−0.685 (0.690)	−0.600 (0.571)
PFL × Mixed	2.250*** (0.516)	2.045*** (0.581)	2.243*** (0.517)	2.037*** (0.580)
PFL × Female-dominated	0.136 (0.545)	0.165 (0.547)	0.129 (0.544)	0.160 (0.547)
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Broad Ind-State FE	No	Yes	No	Yes
Broad Ind-Year FE	No	Yes	No	Yes
Min Wage Control	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	31,012	31,012	31,012	31,012
R ²	0.069	0.087	0.069	0.087

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. Reference category: male-dominated industries (<40% female in 1999). Industry-state and industry-year fixed effects based on 6 broad industry sectors. Individual controls included in all specifications: age, marital status, number of children, education, and race/ethnicity. State-year control: effective state minimum wage (maximum of state and federal minimum wage).

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A5: Effect of PFL on Weeks Worked DDD Full Specification Results

	Weeks Worked
PFL	−0.600 (0.571)
Mixed industry	−1.323*** (0.197)
Female-dominated industry	−0.568** (0.241)
PFL × Mixed	2.037*** (0.580)
PFL × Female-dominated	0.160 (0.547)
Age	0.291*** (0.016)
Married	1.041*** (0.221)
Number of children	−0.648*** (0.084)
High school diploma	3.133*** (0.480)
Some college	3.995*** (0.460)
Bachelor's degree or above	5.026*** (0.512)
Black, non-Hispanic	−1.653*** (0.271)
Hispanic	0.137 (0.255)
Other race/ethnicity	−0.285 (0.338)
Effective minimum wage	−0.073 (0.069)
Constant	33.021*** (0.779)
State FE	Yes
Year FE	Yes
Broad Ind-State FE	Yes
Broad Ind-Year FE	Yes
Observations	31,012
R^2	0.087

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level (51 clusters) in parentheses. Reference categories: male-dominated industries; less than high school; white non-Hispanic. Effective minimum wage defined as the maximum of the state and federal minimum wage.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A6: Heterogeneity by Continuous Female Share

	Weeks Worked
PFL (ref: 40–50% female)	0.549 (0.507)
PFL × <30% female	–0.297 (0.751)
PFL × 30–40% female	–2.124*** (0.750)
PFL × 50–60% female	1.084* (0.557)
PFL × 60–70% female	–2.792*** (0.979)
PFL × 70–80% female	–0.488 (0.832)
PFL × >80% female	1.157 (0.971)
State FE	Yes
Year FE	Yes
Broad Ind-State FE	Yes
Broad Ind-Year FE	Yes
Observations	31,012
R^2	0.088

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level in parentheses. Reference category: industries 40–50% female in 1999. Industry-state and industry-year fixed effects based on 6 broad industry sectors. Controls: age, marital status, number of children, education, race/ethnicity, and effective state minimum wage.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A7: Distribution of Observations by Industry Female Share Band

Industry Female Share	Number of Observations	Percent of Total Sample
<30% female	2,627	8.47
30–40% female	2,278	7.35
40–50% female (ref)	2,649	8.54
50–60% female	6,600	21.28
60–70% female	3,665	11.82
70–80% female	10,627	34.27
>80% female	2,566	8.27
Total	31,012	100.00

Notes: Source: Current Population Survey (IPUMS-CPS), 1999–2025. Sample: Women whose youngest child is under age 1 with any employment in the past 12 months. Female share bands defined using 1999 industry female share of employment. Reference category: 40–50% female.

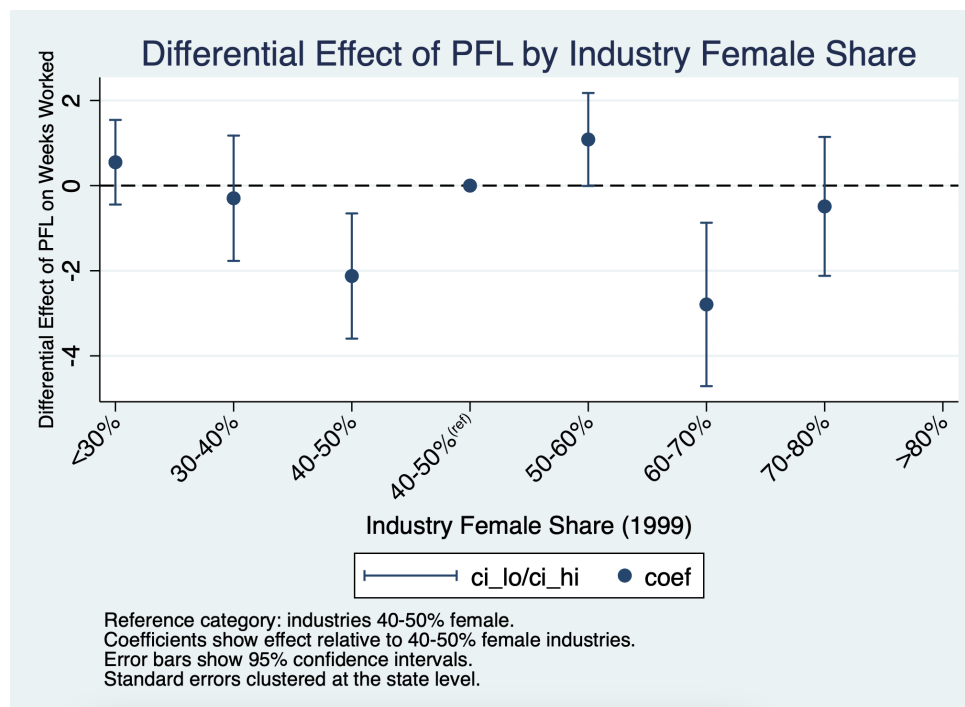
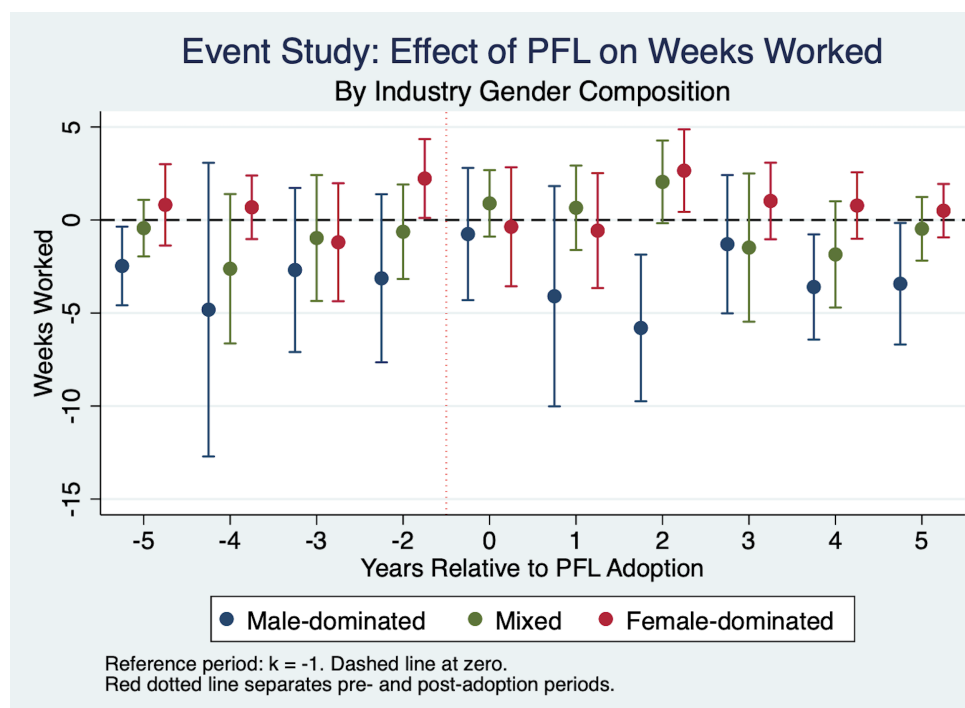
Figure A2: Differential Effect of PFL (7 Industry Groups)**Figure A3: DD Event Study Estimates of PFL Effect on Weeks Worked by Industry Group**

Table A8: DD Event Study Estimates of PFL Effect on Weeks Worked by Industry Group

	(1) Male-Dominated	(2) Mixed	(3) Female-Dominated
$k = -5$	-2.470** (1.053)	-0.437 (0.758)	0.816 (1.088)
$k = -4$	-4.819 (3.930)	-2.620 (1.999)	0.684 (0.850)
$k = -3$	-2.685 (2.196)	-0.968 (1.685)	-1.194 (1.579)
$k = -2$	-3.133 (2.250)	-0.630 (1.264)	2.230** (1.055)
$k = 0$	-0.752 (1.769)	0.895 (0.890)	-0.364 (1.592)
$k = +1$	-4.097 (2.948)	0.656 (1.130)	-0.569 (1.538)
$k = +2$	-5.802*** (1.962)	2.050* (1.107)	2.654** (1.104)
$k = +3$	-1.299 (1.850)	-1.482 (1.984)	1.024 (1.024)
$k = +4$	-3.599** (1.408)	-1.850 (1.422)	0.778 (0.889)
$k = +5$	-3.426** (1.627)	-0.472 (0.851)	0.502 (0.715)
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	4,905	9,249	16,858
R^2	0.083	0.093	0.056

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level (51 clusters) in parentheses. Reference period: $k = -1$. Each column estimates a separate DD regression for the indicated industry group. Controls: age, marital status, number of children, education, race/ethnicity, and effective state minimum wage.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A9: DDD Event Study Estimates of PFL Effect on Weeks Worked by Industry Gender Composition

	Male-Dominated (ref. group)	Mixed (rel. to male-dom.)	Female-Dominated (rel. to male-dom.)
$k = -5$	-0.891 (0.925)	0.864 (0.608)	0.443 (0.904)
$k = -4$	-2.501 (3.290)	1.119 (4.387)	1.852 (3.242)
$k = -3$	-0.121 (1.199)	0.213 (1.333)	-2.316 (1.623)
$k = -2$	-0.905 (1.440)	1.040 (2.122)	1.857 (2.074)
$k = 0$	1.020 (1.456)	0.466 (1.099)	-2.454 (1.839)
$k = +1$	-1.240 (1.827)	2.336 (2.350)	-0.939 (1.735)
$k = +2$	-2.808*** (0.812)	5.551*** (0.974)	3.740* (1.879)
$k = +3$	0.727 (1.396)	-1.292 (2.009)	-1.064 (1.689)
$k = +4$	-1.088 (1.264)	0.306 (1.962)	0.665 (0.937)
$k = +5$	-1.314** (0.534)	2.424*** (0.651)	0.278 (0.461)
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Broad Ind-State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Broad Ind-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	31,012		

Notes: Dependent variable: weeks worked in past year. Standard errors clustered at the state level (51 clusters) in parentheses. Reference period: $k = -1$. Reference group: male-dominated (<40% female in 1999). Mixed and female-dominated columns show differential effects relative to male-dominated. Controls: age, marital status, number of children, education, race/ethnicity, effective state minimum wage. Industry FE based on 6 broad sectors.

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$